

MOTHER MUNDANE

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This thesis takes as its starting point an understanding of art as an encompassing behaviour that connects symbolic thinking, toolmaking, and innovation: a neighbourhood of activities that facilitates knowledge through feelings, perceptions, storytelling, questioning, challenges, and discovery. This combination of approaches is used to reaffirm the intellectual, virtuous, and emotional potential of images and commonplace objects, recovering their capacity as tools for critical analysis. Under the rubric of “Mother Mundane,” I propose a new way of appreciating the objects that construct our symbolic universe and look for ways to expand the scope of existing norms.

Mother Mundane brings together voices, images, and objects, organising them as I would organise materials in my studio, with the ambition of categorising them into coherent chapters of reflection. Through the process of categorization, displacement, and isolation, I speculate within a relative realm, where subtle interventions, quiet humour, and repetitive features become audible. Going back to the elements of nature, to the vital ingredients of Mother Earth, I look at water, a compound, a mixture, the reason we have organic life. I use this as an entry point and connective force between the following accounts of lived experience, theory, studio process, and reflections on specific works I have developed during my MFA.

PARAMOUNT PICTURES

1

THE HIGH LIFE

1.1

At the heart of the Dominican divide of the island of Hispaniola is the Loma Siete Cabezas (Mound of Seven Heads), a modest mountain that is the birthplace of more than twenty rivers that lead in the direction of the capital city of Santo Domingo, where I was based for three years. In this sense, it is the bosom of the capital and of my current artistic practice.

In September of 2014, I travelled to the Dominican Republic for the first time. I worked for three and a half months as an Artist in Residence in Altos de Chavon, alongside two other artists: a Dominican alumnus of the local design school and an American Wall Street banker born again as a portrait painter. Altos de Chavón is a fake sixteenth-century Mediterranean village located above Rio Chavón amidst a luxury resort known as Casa de Campo. It was the brainchild of Charles Bludhorn, chairman of Paramount Pictures, then parent of Gulf and Western. The project began in 1976 when a mountain of stone was blasted through due to the construction of a nearby highway that stretches across Rio Chavón.

The fake village boasts a church named Iglesia San Estanislao de Cracovia after the patron saint of Poland. However, the Church is better known as a venue for celebrity weddings, including that of Louis “King Louis XX” Alphonse, a direct heir to the defunct French throne. A Roman-style 5,000-seat amphitheatre was also built where Frank Sinatra performed at the opening of the village in 1982. The inhabitants and students of Chavón call it a bubble because it exists in a dramatically different dimension to the rest of the island. Chavón is indeed a bubble, but in all its fictional delusion, it retains a very real and conspicuous reality – a complex construction where a multitude of antagonistic ingredients fester: corruption, aspiration, retreat, failure, loneliness, tranquillity, nature, the synthetic, charity, malice, magic, superstition, the superficial, simplicity, sophistication, *chopo*...

SWEET

1.2

Today, Casa de Campo is a kind of fading, glitzy, dystopian bubble, but what was interesting to me was its polar normality. The semi-tragic, half plastic but nevertheless very beautiful coating vs. The profound yet unproclaimed underbelly that holds the place up. The workers, the women who clean the dishes, cook meals, wash the clothes, tend to the garden, sweep and mop the floors, cradle the children, walk the

dogs. The behind-the-scenes legacy of “the living machine,” a term coined by Paul B. Preciado.

“ The first machines of the industrial revolution were not the steam engine, the printing press or the guillotine... but the slave labourer of the plantation, the sexual and reproductive worker, and the animal. The first machines of the industrial revolution were living machines. Humanism then invented another body that it would call human: a sovereign, white, heterosexual, healthy, seminal body. A stratified body and full of organs, full of capital, the gestures of which are measured by time and of which the desires are the effects of a necropolitical technology of pleasure. Liberty, equality, fraternity: animalism unveils the colonial and patriarchal roots of the universal principles of European humanism. The regime of slavery, then salaried labour, appeared as the foundation of the freedom of modern “man”; expropriation and the segmentation of life and knowledge as the reverse of equality; war, competition and rivalry as operators of fraternity.

The Renaissance, the Enlightenment, the miracle of the industrial revolution, therefore, rest on the reduction of slaves and women to the status of animals and on the reduction of the three (slaves, women and animals) to that of (re)productive machines. If the animal was one day conceived of and treated as a machine, the machine became little by little a technoanimal living with technoliving animals. The machine and the animal (migrants, bodies, pharmacopornographics, children of the sheep Dolly, electronumerical brains) constitute themselves as the new political subjects of the animalism to come. The machine and the animal are quantic homonyms.¹ (page 20)

Preciado's concept encapsulates precisely what I mean by the “underbelly workforce.” During my residency at Casa de Campo, I could see people who were like ghosts, unseen and quietly going about their work. Colonial imagery prevailed, hearty Dominican meals were served on fine ceramics, Spanish colonial architecture, archetypal palm trees, maids dressed in white linen.

Linen, a pure vegetable fibre, has come to symbolize healing, but it is also a means to transmit illness and disease. In a place like DR with such monstrous historical wounds, the bandages are dense. Extensive layers have to be stripped back one by one. It's a slow process. There are no short cuts, the damage has been done so it can't be erased – even in a country with “bleach culture,” the dirt is so deeply rooted that remnants will somehow always be visible. Even if we try to solve or move on from such problems by setting fire to

them, we are still left with the fumes to inhale. Fumes generously tear across the resort, from the bleach-drenched interiors to the smell of burning sugar from the neighbouring refinery, to the fogs of fumigation that waft across the golf courses and gardens. Under these cumulus clouds, it seems like the inhabitants of Casa de Campo have become high. Villa owners lose perception as a result of their reverse incarceration, and the workers remain on a permanent sugar high from chewing sugar cane and drinking Jugo con leche.

The sweet and sensitive legacy of the living machine that I observed made me think of Federico García Lorca and his praise of nuns “that nourish the imagination of rich children with traditional music and poetry. Illiterate, earthy, good-natured and an inexhaustible fund of country love. Wet nurses maids and other lowly domestics performing the extraordinary task of taking ballads and songs into aristocratic and bourgeois homes.”² (page 20)

At the end of my residency, I installed a used mop from the art gallery onto the wall as a small tribute to the living machine.

FIGURE 1

Hannah Parr, *Dozens of clothes pegs*, 2020, from the installation *Dignity of labor*, 2014, exhibited at the artist in residency exhibition in Altos de Chavon. The clothes pegs were bought from a supermarket in La Romana the town that borders Casa de Campo. After the exhibition, I dismantled the installation and shipped them along with the used mop back to Europe.



MOTHER EARTH

1.3

A couple of months after my residency, I returned to the DR to take part in an exhibition at a gallery in La Zona (the Colonial Zone in Santo Domingo) and organised a studio in La Zona so that I could prepare for the show. It became my studio of three years. It was situated beside the mouth of the Rio Ozama that opens up to the Caribbean Sea.

Rio Ozama divides the eastern, northern, and western parts of the city of Santo Domingo. It has become highly polluted as factories dump their waste directly into it. Along the river's edge there are slums that house communities of marginalized people and poor families. Frequent heavy rain causes the water levels to rise. As a result, personal belongings from the shacks are snatched up by the current and carried out in the direction of the Caribbean sea. At the mouth of the river, tides distribute these items to shore, and when the tide withdraws these items litter the beach next to the Obelisco Hembra (female Obelisk) del Malecon.

Here, you can find person-sized dunes of plastic, domestic items, and lost personal belongings. On this beach I often passed drawers from vanity tables still filled with their original contents:

plastic bottles, hair rollers, and combs.

This is where the late Dominican artist and activist Tony Capellán collected his materials. He worked exclusively with materials brought forth by the Caribbean Sea, each piece of plastic he collected was specific to a specific social situation. He collected this material in reaction to what was happening along the coastline – it was his daily routine. Out of this mass of lost plastic, he built ephemeral installations, seeing the potential to build stories that voiced the conditions of marginalised and poor families, the voices of the many farmers that have been forced off their land and moved to the city. Often people are quick to remark and make jokes about how terribly people drive in Santo Domingo, but the simple reason for this is that farmers were literally forced off their land and went from riding donkeys to driving Hondas, so with this in mind it's easy to understand why the roads are as chaotic as they are. But the problem is people tend not to have this kind of understanding in mind, and this is why Capellán's work was so important. By perceiving this trash as a direct testament to the brutal legacies of colonialism, racism, and poverty

in his country, he found a vernacular language that could be understood by the owners of the lost flip-flops and hair combs, yet his work was so elegantly accomplished it could also become the subject of international discourse on museum platforms.

He was a medium: committed to working with the incongruous materials the sea continues to bring forth. His scope of understanding nurtured the voices of disparaged communities and the voice of nature. Materials – alien or not – have a relationship to the land, the land is a spiritual entity. Therefore, to me, Capellán was the personification of Mother Earth and has now become Mother Earth.

FIGURE 2

Tony Capellán, *Flotando*, 2013, a sculpture from his solo exhibition at Centro Cultural de España in Santo Domingo



Santo Domingo has its back to the sea, which seems fitting, given how little interest is paid to the alien materials that arise from the sea and pollute its shores. Downtown, in the opposite direction, other kinds of alien imports are found, namely from the U.S.: cars, valet parking services, pacas de ropas, shopping malls, baseball, and celebrity culture. Like the fraying edge of a heterogeneous carpet, the Malecon is home to the freaks. Hope is harboured at the water's edge: the pink clouds at sunset are rosy from teenage love, cotton candy, and the American dream.

THE MARILYN MONROE OF SANTO DOMINGO

1.4

"The Marilyn Monroe of Santo Domingo" was written by Dominican poet Frank Baez, who I became close friends with while based in Santo Domingo. He is a native author of the Dominican diaspora and the first person to introduce me to the artist Tony Capellán.

I'm the Marilyn Monroe of Santo Domingo.
I'm six foot four.
Two inches more when I wear high heels.
I have a beauty spot on my butt.

I date poets from the eighties.
I date handymen, security guards,
models, engineers, visual artists,
weight lifters, lawyers, white boys,
paper pushers, heavy hitters, car valets.

I'm a regular at the bingo parlor,
the woman who puts *Leaves
of Grass* in her pocketbook
and gets lost in space.
The woman who drinks coffee at bus stops,
the man-eater, the pythoness, the megapoet,
the woman who cries when the movie ends
and nobody gives her a hug.
I'm a menstruating monster,
the woman who sits in the dance joints and drinks,
who ties one on and makes the whores

look disgusted and burns their miniskirts
with cigarettes when they go by.
The woman who wanted to kidnap Anthony Ríos.
The woman who injects hormones in her legs.
I'm la Cicciolina.
I'm Tiresias.

The woman who writes buck naked.
That big-boned woman who's
multiplied by the motel mirrors
when they do her doggy-style.
The woman who sits in the back pew
of the church with a black eye.
Miss Boca Chica nineteen-ninety-four.
That woman who smokes on the ocean boulevard
watching the ships with their lights turned on.
The second semester nursing student.
The white girl who drives ambulances, city buses,
passenger vans, trailer trucks.
I'm the MARILYN MONROE OF SANTO DOMINGO.

I'm the MARILYN MONROE OF SANTO DOMINGO.
No, no, that thing was still there.
I hadn't chopped it off.
I didn't have the money to do it with.
So one day I thought I'm gonna do readings
to raise the money and have that operation.
I called all my poet friends on the telephone.
I remember how they passed a basket around
like they do at Masses
and there I was standing on the stage
the pur-tee Marilyn Monroe of Santo Domingo
reading my verses and grateful for the applause.
Thank you poet friends.
Thank you Mr. Minister of Culture.
Thank you very much.

A mob follows me with rocks.
They stone me in the Mella. They stone me
at the Car Wash in San Isidro,
the ones in Los Mameyes, the Charles and Villa Mella.
Behind Quisqueya Stadium.
They beat me, humiliate me, shout at me.
They give me a thrashing.
They pile on top of me one by one.
I've lost myself.

I'm no longer here.
 I repeat: I've lost myself
 and don't know how to find myself.
 I go to the four cardinal points looking for myself
 in a procession with all the women I've been
 and those that I'll be and those that I can't be.
 I sleep in hospital beds,
 guesthouses, motels, parks.
 I take showers. Lots of showers.
 The dye runs down my face
 and down my makeup.
 I feel like I'm coming apart
 and pieces of me keep falling one by one
 taking the shower water with them
 the water keeps falling and taking me with it
 down to the drain.

Here I am on the rear of a Setenta motorbike.
 Dancing with three men on a patio.
 Walking on a busted high heel.
 Massaging Italian tourists.
 Sitting on my suitcase at an intersection
 trying to hitch a ride.
 Two guys in a Toyota pull up.
 The one who's driving asks me
 Hey white girl where you goin' babe
 and I answer goin to LA
 all the way down to LA
 you know, Los Alcarrizos.
 They leave me thirteen kilometers further on.
 I walk to the other side of the road
 and they hang around looking at me
 till on this side a Leche Rica
 milk truck stops
 and I climb in.
 (Here I open a parenthesis to advise you
 you need to get an AIDS test.
 I do one every year.
 They give it to you in a week at most.
 A hundred and eighty pesos near the UASD.)

I go with divorced guys, widowers, atheists, priests, art critics,
 psychoanalysts, ex-suicides, salsa-lovers, scooter-drivers,
 Haitians, Protestant pastors, clowns, the terminally ill,
 schizos, broke boxers.

I wake up in Puerto Plata.
 I have visions in Azua.
 I see the Pope dancing salsa.
 I see igloos in Haina and Tres Brazos.
 Eskimos in mom-and-pop stores. Penguins in Mao.
 St. Augustine with eyelashes like Charityn.
 UFOs abducting senators and congressmen.

There's a country in the world placed in the sun's very path.
 There's in the world a very country placed in the sun's path.
 There's the sun's very path placed in a country in the world.

There's the sun's path in the very world placed in a country.
 I travel to New York with a fake passport.

MARILYN MONROE walking down Fifth Avenue again.
 MARILYN MONROE WITH A THREE-DAY BEARD.

I have breakfast at Tiffany's.
 I drink Champagne in limousines.
 I run for my life in Corona.
 I play the accordion at a corner.
 I fight in SoHo.
 I cry in front of the Hudson.
 I give a reading at the Nuyorican Café.
 Rhymesters, poets, and rappers
 toss me sprays of flowers.
 I sign autographs.
 I spread kisses all around.
 Suddenly the doors bust wide open.
 The INS guys put me in handcuffs.
 They push me and meanwhile
 the audience boos them and throws bottles.
 Shots are heard.
 They deport me.

I'm the Marilyn Monroe of Santo Domingo.
 I get a waxjob all over.
 Powder myself. Do my make-up.
 Put on a fur coat
 ready for my next reading.
 I'm the MARILYN MONROE OF SANTO DOMINGO.
 I'm the MARILYN MONROE OF SANTO DOMINGO.
 I'm the MARILYN MONROE OF SANTO DOMINGO.
 What's a girl to do?³ (page 20)

BRITISH

2

FIGURE 3

Sebastian Meyer, 'Monica looks at a cross over the bathroom door while her abusive boyfriend, Sebastian, takes a shower' from the series Crackney, a photographic story about addiction in the Hackney neighborhood in London



FOOTNOTES:

1

Paul B. Preciado, "Feminism beyond humanism, ecology beyond the environment" (first published in *Liberation*, Sep. 26, 2014)

2

Ian Gibson, *Federico García Lorca (Biography)* (Faber and Faber, 1989 London. Print.)

3

Frank Baez, *The Marilyn Monroe of Santo Domingo*, from *Last Night I Dreamt I was a DJ*, translated by P. Scott Cunningham & Hoyt Rogers (Miami, Jai-Alai Books, 2014. Print.)

2.1

British was the name of one of the women that frequented the DIY drop-in Pamper Parlour. One side of her face had dropped from being beaten so many times. Every Tuesday, St. Paul's Church on Stoke Newington Road in London (circa 2007) opened its doors to welcome crack-addicted sex workers into a safe, unbiased space where they could feel at home and build a network amongst themselves, finding strength and a sense of family as a group of sisters. It was an initiative set up by a friend of mine, Kaye Dunnings, Creative Director of Shangri-La at Glastonbury Festival and founder of the performance art group *The Laundrettas*. I, too, was part of this collective. We developed a nomadic installation called *The Laundromat of Love*, which in essence was a DIY pamper parlour offering quite straightforwardly "Laundry," but in the form of makeover services and laughter.

It was a fundamentally playful set up that involved a lot of basic games borrowed from childhood, and these became a vehicle to combat inhibition and get people laughing on a very basic level.

What we did always ran the risk of being perceived as whimsical, which in a way it was, but the crux of this supposed silliness was actually very serious,

which is why we received many invitations to collaborate with organisations such as Bonkersfest⁴ (page 36) and the Women's Open Doors clinic. The difference between a regular women's health clinic and St. Paul's was that it wasn't a health clinic at all, nor were any of us trained nurses or psychiatrists. All we offered were some plastic chairs, plastic bowls filled with warm water, and equipment such as hair combs, shampoo, fresh towels, bobby pins, hair ties, creams, nail polish, and remover. Most of the time we just washed, combed, and re-styled hair.

We disentangled hair with plastic combs as we listened to hard tales from the night before, often in the most intimate silence.

It was Kaye's empathy, open mind, and mischievous attitude that masterminded the right balance between the profound and the therapeutic, with a good measure of comedy. Kaye the instigator always encouraged games, once climbing onto the stage in the church hall and disappearing behind the red curtain only to re-enter, not as a born-again

Christian but as a transformed woman. Those that followed her might only dare at first to expose a foot or a leg, but others like British emerged with a myriad of fantastic personas. It was a simple and hilarious exercise to help rebuild self-esteem. These Tuesdays were likely the one time in the week the women had the possibility to let go, relearn what a safe space feels like, and have a laugh.

Perhaps we have all experienced that certain things can only be said, explained, or done with one other person, like sharing a secret which both know cannot be shared with anyone else. Certain things cannot be told – not for reasons of discretion or because they have to do with sex or addiction, but because all profound connections are ineffable.

To me, empathy is a social forecast and an important custom that must be continually expanded. As I helped at the drop-in, I wasn't thinking at all about the role of the artist in society. Although I was studying for a degree in graphic design at Central Saint Martins, I spent most of my free time with Kaye and *The Laundrettas* because what this exposed me to was much more compelling than life inside the academy. Growing up I learnt from my father how to draw and observe the world through my sketchbook: my sketchbook was my studio.

Today my sketchbooks are more animated and have transformed into a three-plus dimensional practice that occurs in and out of the studio, an embodiment of real-life experience, material investigation, and intuition.

The German artist Kathe Kollwitz recognized that she could express something greater than her own feelings and that her work could serve not just herself but an entire society.

Grief and loss are comprehensive feelings that bind us together, and sharing these feelings

with others can lead to compassion and social transformation.

FIGURE 4

Still from the unfinished film *Something's Got to Give*, George Cukor (20th Century Fox, 1962). Shortly before her death from barbiturates, Monroe emerges from blue water that appears like a shimmering sea behind her.



2.2

To serve one's every need

On November 18, 2017, I travelled to Chios for the first time to volunteer with CESRT (Chios Eastern Shore Response Team)⁵ (page 36). At the time, CESRT were in collaboration with the children's house, an initiative set up by Janne Hega, who was a coordinator for One Drop in the Ocean⁶ (page 36), an organisation that supports refugees in Lesbos, northern Greece, and Athens. One Drop in the Ocean's main focus is on supporting mothers and children, as it was for the children's house. This 40 sqm, two-room apartment in the town centre of Chios was intended to serve as a drop-in centre for mothers and children. The micro-facility had one shower within a broom-cupboard-sized space, a hammam that was equipped with a changing table for babies, shelves packed from floor to ceiling with nappies, diapers, and pampers, and a cupboard filled with toiletries (such as toothbrushes, toothpaste, nappy rash cream, soap, combs, and razors), a hairdryer, brand new underwear, and fresh socks. Over the hallway was a room the size of a walk-in closet that was filled with children's clothes. Adjacent to the entrance was a lounge and play area where children had access to toys, books, and drawing materials.

As mentioned, this "house" was initially intended to be a place for mothers and children only, but the reality is that many mothers have been lost. Therefore, fathers must assume the roles of both parents. Or, as I commonly saw, if both parents have been lost, the older children must take care of the younger ones. In any case, families eventually had the opportunity to bring their children for a warm shower and receive donations. After 24 hours of volunteer work with CESRT, I recognised that my time was best spent in the children's house, particularly in the hammam.

I spent every day of those first three weeks in Chios in the hammam.

This is the one time in my life that I felt I could justly let go of my work as an artist.

In November 2017, there were about 2,400 people in Vial Refugee Camp—over 1,000 of whom were children. The camp's official capacity was 800, and the weather was very wet, cold, and windy. The campsite is located 8 km from Chios centre, and while there was a bus service, it was limited to one bus per hour. Additionally, it wasn't free of charge and was due to stop running the following month.

Under such restrictions, we were still able to serve an average of 30 families each day, with an average of 85 children and 1,000 Pampers distributed daily. At first, mothers were also invited to take a shower as they showered their children, but as the numbers grew so high a queue of families formed from 8 am until the end of the day at 7 pm. This meant that in order to serve as many children as possible it became impossible to invite mothers to shower themselves (naturally with some exceptions).

The number of visitors versus the size of the facility meant that the atmosphere was manic and just as chaotic as life in the campsite Vial, the only differences being that it wasn't submerged in mud and the roof wasn't a tarpaulin that was collapsing on us. But the hammam was a fifteen-minute retreat, a restorative realm, squeezed inside a 2 m² shoe box and somewhat isolated from the chaos outside. The children's house was so intense that closing the door was like sealing a vacuum, with the slurp of silence flooding and massaging my ears each time.

The first thing I tended to was to seat the children on the (only) two plastic stools we had and promptly give them a Dallmann's sage lozenge. This became a routine tactic which calmed and at the same time induced co-operation, which was essential given the size of the families and short amount of time each was given. Besides this, all of the children had a barking cough. When you meet such numbers of children and learn what they have gone through and what is still to come, it's dreadful to see their suffering, not to mention the psychological trauma.

For the mothers who must cope with a corral of babies and survive living in a tent, and not for a short while, the slightest bit of physical or moral aid was clearly worth its weight in gold. Some mothers often seemed to appreciate just having someone to talk to, particularly the unbiased ear of a stranger that was willing to listen. I remember one very sweet family entering from Syria (which along with Iraq and Afghanistan were the most prominent countries represented). The father was present and attentive. He took the children's coats and waited outside. I began to chat with the mother, and we got the children organised for their shower. She was a psychologist (about the same age as me) who spoke very good English. Noticing their togetherness, I said to her, "You are a beautiful family." She replied, "Yes we are, but we lost one daughter in an air bomb attack, which is why we came." She continued that they had reached their limit and that of course they didn't want to come here, but couldn't risk losing any more. They were relatively new arrivals, having spent just two weeks in Vial. Then,

pointing towards the ruckus just beyond the door, she said, "But you know what? The worst thing about Vial is those women out there!" The women were brawling with each other over their place in line and harassing volunteers for more donations.

It's hard to describe the anxiety of life inside the campsite. Once, a mother that I had met a few times confessed, "If it weren't for the children's house, I wouldn't have survived." Just knowing that she could take her children even once per week for a hot shower and be welcomed with warm smiles is what got her through. As she spoke, her daughter climbed me like a tree and wrapped herself around my waist she sang repeatedly "I love you" in Arabic.

Working inside the hammam gave me the most tender insights into an integrated spectrum of war, of cultural and economic disparity, displacement, and humanitarian crisis. It gave me an understanding of colossal disasters on a personal level learned through highly mundane functional situations.

It was a reality check that cut through falsified stereotypes, bringing home that we all have a body that shares the same functions as other "foreign" bodies, and that the differences that give birth to war do not actually apply to us on a one-to-one level.

I mentioned that eventually we had to prioritise children's showers over those of mothers, but I made numerous hidden exceptions. One of these occasions was with a mother (again, around my age or younger) who had two very young children. She shined with so much excitement over the prospect of hot running water in a private bathroom that I told her she could go ahead and shower herself too. I helped with her two youngsters, and she unwrapped her scarf or hijab, revealing her bleached platinum blond hair. It was a surprising moment on many levels: Marilyn Monroe of the East was in the house!

It was brilliant and mundanely beautiful. This simple action shined a light on a complex and taboo subject and offered a distinct perspective on a tradition that is so muddled and so controversial.

According to Dr. Asma Lamrabet, an Islamic feminist author, the term *hijab*, which is frequently used to refer to a headscarf, does not absolutely mean the scarf that covers the hair of Muslim women. Nowhere in the Qur'an does the term *hijab* reflect this meaning. The semantic and conceptual interpretation of the Qur'anic term *hijab* is very different from everyday reality. Lamrabet quotes the following example: "O you who have believed, do not enter the houses of the Prophet except when you are permitted for a meal... And when you ask [his wives] for something, ask them from behind a separation (*hijab*)" (Quran 33:53).⁷ (page 36)

As indicated here, the *hijab* concerns only the wives of the Prophet and meets a circumstantial requirement in order to respect the private life of the Prophet. Besides, it does not represent in any way a particular form of clothing. The essential aim was to remind Arabs of the time to respect the privacy of others and reinforce good manners. Interestingly, this passage relates quite closely to what the hammam in our children's house offered: a chance to respect the privacy of people and uphold good manners.

Another heartbreaking situation revolved around the teenaged girls. We've all encountered the ordeals of puberty, but these kids also needed to act as mothers to their younger siblings. I'd never seen the level of exhaustion that I saw in them. It went beyond the physical – you could see it rendered deep in their eyes. My reflex was to just comb their hair, accept each aggravated gesture aimed at me with softness, and absorb like a sponge some of the grief they carried on their shoulders. I knew that I was steady and felt sure that my hands could consume some of their burden.

Again, I was using a plastic comb to non-aggressively and understandingly undo knots and tangles. As this tool recurs throughout my life, I see how it offers a direct point of contact, one that is unique and metaphysical. Yet the sheer ordinariness of the tool cloaks its power to make effective connections in a very direct and straightforward way.

Perhaps it was my experience at the drop-in at St. Paul's in Hackney that taught me this or just the rawness of the situation that calls up a more animalistic and natural modes of conduct.

These are just a few of the many hard testimonies inside the hammam about why and how people came to Chios and of the living conditions in Vial. It is indeed a war zone, which I witnessed for myself on my second night. Our team received a phone call informing us that many self-made shelters on the outspill at Vial had collapsed due to heavy rain. We drove to the warehouse to collect hammers and mallets, as well as plastic bin bags, plastic woven UNHCR rugs, and blankets. The official NGOs on the island work office hours with the exception of SMH and Fontex; therefore, CESRT are the only independent team that remain responsive throughout the night. The first person I talked to in the camp was a Syrian man. He was a big guy wearing a women's winter coat. It was wet and freezing cold. The campsite is set up on the hills, away from the town centre, away from everything. I told him my name, which happened to be the same as his family name – Hanna. Right away he said, "OK, you have the same name as me. I have five babies inside this tent. We can't live like this, so please take them."

Inside and outside of the hammam, there was much more to attend to than combing hair. I would help tidy mud-covered clothes into countless plastic bags. I saw that almost none of the children had underwear to put back on after they showered, so I made sure we provided new underwear, not in the open clothes-distribution area, but inside the privacy of the hamman. This may seem obvious, but volunteers naturally try to work fast and serve as many people as possible. In such a frenzy, it's easy to get caught up in the drama and stop paying attention to small details.

Reflecting on this work now, I can relate it to how I focus on my work as an artist. My practice is led by my interest in investigating the greater potential that small details or seemingly mundane fragments embody. In Chios, I behaved as I would ordinarily, taking care to pay attention to the details that have both a particular and binding function.

Let's say the crisis in Chios is a kind of cyclone. Picture a hurricane that you could "pause" and then scroll back and forth to view it. Its messiness would be preserved, but in perfect stillness. Then, it could be carefully observed and, finally, details within this paused chaos would be revealed. Closing the door of the hammam to the frenzy happening outside was like pausing a hurricane.

Referring back to my artistic practice, I believe these are the ideal conditions for good work. If you are observant, you don't need to present all the debris born of the hurricane (a process that I am still learning, Justified in the way that we call it a practice, it's an evolution.)

In the case of my volunteering it operates much in the same way, the greatest differences are made through tending to the simplest – mundane actions. They help to bridge a gap between what we as individuals hold in common inside an otherwise overwhelming cyclone of a humanitarian crisis. This is why I say magic is found in the mundane. By shutting the door of the hammam and slowing down the hurricane, another world was formed: a floating space that not only revolves around basic bodily functions but is capable of reestablishing raw and natural connections. To me this was magical – that out of such complexity, simple objects such a plastic hair comb could become a tool that transcends unimaginable crisis.

I could never have anticipated the experiences I had volunteering and that so many deep and unique relationships would be built between strangers. But I was also surprised how little I understood about our basic daily needs. If thousands of people are placed on a mountainside without sufficient water or bathroom facilities, then what is really crucial is an abundance of diapers, commonly known as Pampers. I had no idea that I would stand there in the hammam saying "Pampers" around 100 times a day. More shocking is that both

children and adults needed them. Women asked for them because in the camp they won't walk to the porter-loo "bathroom" or go outside their tent at night; otherwise, they'd run the risk of being raped. Boredom and frustration stew inside the campsite. Like Mr. Hanna, many I met said that had they known the campsite conditions were so bad they would not have come. This was something that puzzled me, as everyone seemed to have a smartphone, or a telephone at least. Why wasn't news traveling back to relatives and friends warning of the reality of life in the campsite and the reality of how long it takes for people to receive the paperwork they need to leave Vial. This was the utterly devastating part about the boat landings: to see people experience intoxicated joy, gratitude, and relief on surviving the boat journey only to board a coach that would take them up to the campsite.

Two months after my first trip to Chios, I travelled back to help with the construction of a new facility for the children's house, now renamed the Iris Center ⁸ (page 36). It was a warehouse that was within walking distance to Vial and large enough to house four family-sized showers, a play area, a sofa area, a craft table, and a wardrobe area for self-selected clothes donations, which was almost as big as our entire previous location. In addition, there was a garden, and a sewing hut was even set up that could be used for making adjustments to the stockpiles of random unsorted donations that arrive on the island. It was a great collective achievement. The facility opened in March, and, when I saw it again in May, it was an absolute joy to see the difference that having such a space made. Sadly in November 2018, after nine months of operation, the lease on the warehouse was abruptly ended, and now the Iris Center operates as a mobile unit (a van and container lock up for donations) that distributes clothes, Pampers, strollers, and shoes near Vial by depositing them on a tarpaulin on the ground.

THE OCEAN

2.3

On my numerous trips to Chios, I salvaged rubber boat material from the coastlines between Karfas beach and Megas Limnionas where many volunteers stay in a hostel. Sundays were our off days (unless you were on call). I spent them walking along the beach gathering remains of rubber boats and rubber inner tubes that are used in boat crossings as substitute buoyancy aids. As is often the case when I collect found material. I didn't have an immediate idea of what to do

with it – not to say that I mindlessly haul whatever is available. Rather, I make an immediate decision, or a connection is made that spurs me to carry it back to the studio, which is where it then becomes a tool for reflection.

When I returned to Berlin, I washed the rubber material in my bathroom and hung it on my drying rack. There I saw it suspended like a wasted skin. Having not fully processed what I experienced in Chios, I knew that I needed some time to consider how this material could be used and what it could do. So I packed it up and a few months later relocated to Zurich to begin my MFA. Towards the end of my first semester, I unpacked these boxes and hung them out again as I did in my bathroom, activating a reflective process on my experience in Chios and how the wasted boat bodies could function as artworks.

Figure 5

Hannah Parr, *The Ocean* (detail), 2019, 120cm x 90cm x 40cm / 50cm x 50cm, rubber boat remains and beech wood



FIGURE 6

Hannah Parr, *The Ocean*, 2019, 120cm x 90cm x 40cm / 50cm x 50cm, rubber boat remains and beech wood



The outcome of this work was that I designed a free-standing multifaceted frame to be built out of natural beech wood and draped the largest section of boat material over it. Seeing the material draped over the drying rack in my bathroom and then over a wooden frame in my studio, I recalled what I had seen in Chios. The raft's worn skin highlighted multiple processes of reduction. I felt that the bareness and relentlessness of the entire situation was reflected in this material, and I was interested to see how these abstracted planes of neutral colour, tone, and texture could function as a series of paintings.

There are two separate series in this body of work entitled *The Ocean* and *The Ocean (Blue)*. I chose to use the word "ocean" instead of "the sea" or "the Aegean sea," as I wanted the works to stand not only for the situation in Chios, but to provide metaphors and visions that encompass many countries and many situations. *The Ocean* consists of just two elements or items. I say "items" because they are after all artifacts from the sea. I felt that it was important to show the larger of the pieces in the round and that it should be draped and exposed as a gesture towards the nakedness of the realities experienced by the people I met on their journey.

This raw and freestanding element is juxtaposed with a smaller element for which I chose a formal display (classically framed in beech wood). The sides of the frame are angled at a 35-degree angle pointing inward towards the plane of material. I was interested to see what effect this might have. What happens when this material enters a frame and "decorates" a white wall? Or appears like an expensive artwork? Does it draw one towards it for a closer inspection of the worn fibres? Do these fibres reflect damaged personal and social tissue? Perhaps only if the viewer is told that this was the intention?

But what I am more interested in is if these tones and textures are a powerful enough tool to emotionally connect and communicate with the viewer, in the absence of any knowledge of the back story (the most likely scenario) After all, how is a painting signified and what kind of object is it? And although this work is not composed of paint, does it not resonate with abstract expressionist colour field painting?

Perhaps most importantly, who grants authorship of such a work? The sea? The migrants? Or the artist? And do I have permission to "make" such a work? *Did* I even make it? Or, am I just questioning the tradition of painting – investigating if it is (as Mark Rothko put it) indeed possible to express such complex thought through simple expression?

What I really want to know is if the presence of these works sparks a process of contemplation in the viewer. Can they spur active participation and arouse unique emotional experiences, akin to the inwardness I experienced at the drop-in at St. Paul's or the hammam in Chios, an inwardness we have all at some point experienced?

To me, this would be the ultimate achievement, as I believe this inward sense is essential to the notion of a self-aware individual – it is a tool in its own right that connects social awareness to the empathetic understanding of others.

CUT: A CONVERSATION BETWEEN THE AUTHOR AND ERIK STEINBRECHER

FOOTNOTES:

4

Bonkersfest was a free music and arts festival held in Camberwell, South London, which aimed to approach mental distress and health issues and people who are affected by them with positivity and creativity, to challenge stigmatization and exclusion, and to celebrate psychological diversity. It was created and led by the psychiatric survivor's movement organization.

5

CESRT is a small team of independent volunteers that provide immediate humanitarian care at migrant boat landings. They are in collaboration with the Basque NGO SMH (Salvamento Marítimo Humanitario) who immediately inform CESRT of boat landings. Every day since 2015, CESRT has organised two groups of volunteers to take "on-call" shifts that last for 24 hours. At a landing, SMH will first check to see if anyone needs immediate medical or emergency treatment. Then CERST distribute dry clothes, diapers, and blankets and offer food and water. The boats cross a 7-kilometer distance from Turkey, <https://www.cesrt.org/>

6

A Drop in the Ocean, <https://www.drapenihavet.no/en/home/>

7

Dr Asma Lamrabet, 'How does the Qur'an address the issue of Muslim woman's veil or 'Hijab'? Asma lambret, http://www.asma-lamrabet.com/articles/how-does-the-qur-an-address-the-issue-of-muslim-woman-s-veil-or-hijab/#_ednref1, (July 2019).

8

The Iris center, <https://iriscenter.no/>

I hadn't spoken a word to anyone since the previous Friday. That's not unusual – I was at home, writing. Erik, on the other hand, arrived in my studio having had many conversations. He commenced ours by telling me he planned to take his seminar students to visit '*Can You Feel It?*', an exhibition I participated in at Last Tango, an independent off-space in Zurich. He asked if I could join his group there and which work I have on show. I tell him my piece is called *Great Hair*.

They chose it?

We sit down and Erik looks straight ahead at a piece of wood I installed on the wall. He recognises it as a table.

He continues to remark about the construction of this type of table and tells me that it is a material that has some presence in his life relating to architecture. He then tells me about a design for the interior skeleton of such a tabletop. It was a decent design, but the structure consisted of vertical supporting props made out of metal, which meant that as soon as one put pressure on an open unsupported area it would collapse and the metal props would smash through.

We look back up at the wood on the wall and he comments that these surfaces are good for attaching things. In short, they make good displays. He's looking at the staples that are gunned into the surface. Did you use it for a display?

Did you find this?

But it's cut. Did you find it like this?

(laughs) You cut it – that's nice.

It's like the assistant of Martin Kippenberger, Micheal Krebber. He cuts surfboards. But you did this without thinking about turning it into an artwork?

He designs it.

You move within a context [looking around], you speculate, you side step. But are you making artworks? The objects in this studio relate to each other, in their grouping and isolation. You are not a "plinth person."

Yes, it's on a black plinth.

Yes, it is a table.

No, I didn't staple it, they are there because that's how the tabletop surface is attached to the wood frame on the interior.

Yes.

No, I cut it.

I was curious to see the inside (thought: and it seemed like a good place to cut it).

Well, I have been thinking about this. This behaviour, these processes, habits that are not exclusive to humans. My cat bites out a curve on one corner of every cardboard box he lies in so that his head rests more comfortably.

Yes.

I'm looking at these pieces here at the moment [pointing at two chocks of wood with right angles cut into them]. Looking at how the top two speak about a square without the presence of a square. And how the bottom pieces [pointing to two blocks of wood that have

You've been in Berlin a long time. You probably know the artist Andreas...

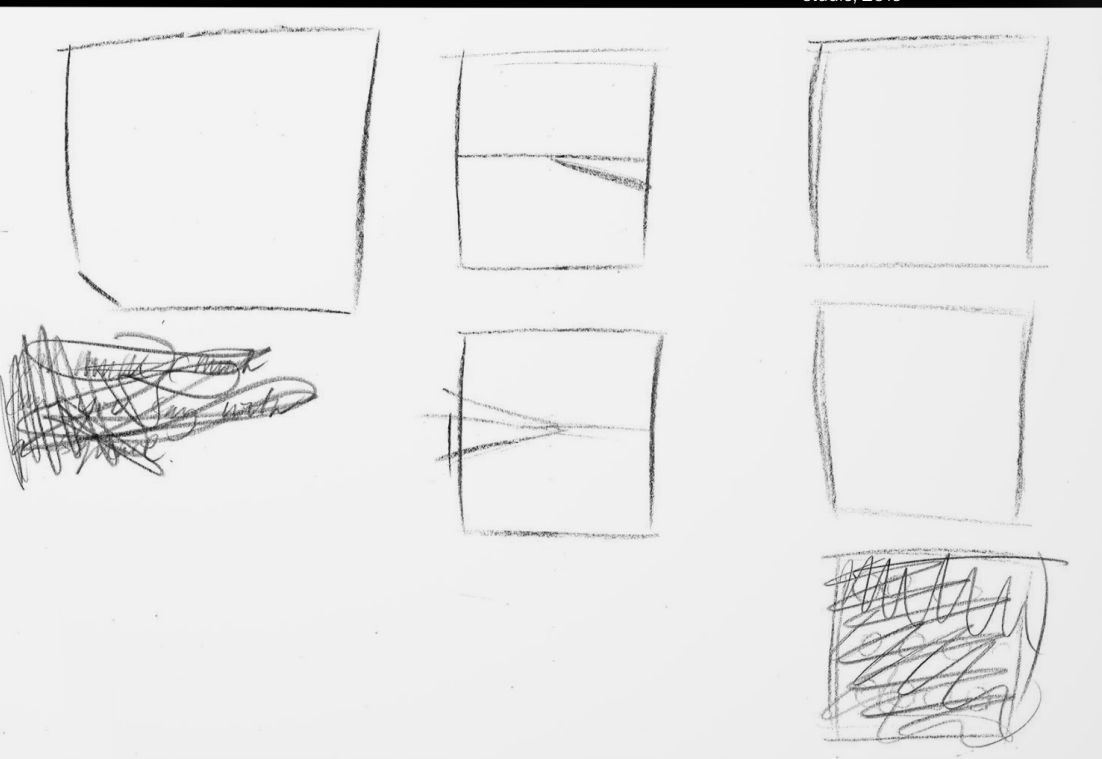
Egal. Anyway he gathered tins of paint – enough tins of paint to paint the Fernsehen tower. And that was his piece. I mean, who cares and it's absurd, but it creates a vision and *that's* great.

If you say, "This is a right angle for a square," I think what square and then there it is. I see that a lot here.

What are these drawings over here? [pointing at two sketches]

FIGURE 7

Hannah Parr, *Plans for squares*, sketches from the studio, 2019



been sawn into] speak of a blade that also isn't there. This is challenging me at the moment as I write my master's thesis. How to write without describing. As soon as you explain, you kill everything.

No.

These are plans for squares, and these I don't know. I just drew them they are just sketches of these pieces of wood over there.

Plans for squares? You see, that's great. I don't want to interfere with your thesis, but perhaps you should include some of these drawings. It's nice to look at, but it's also an opportunity to show something other than your finished work.

It's a dry brush.

But it's small so it must have been for touch-ups.

So you could investigate and find out where the colour on the brush is from, or you can use fiction and say this is *the* paintbrush from Venice.

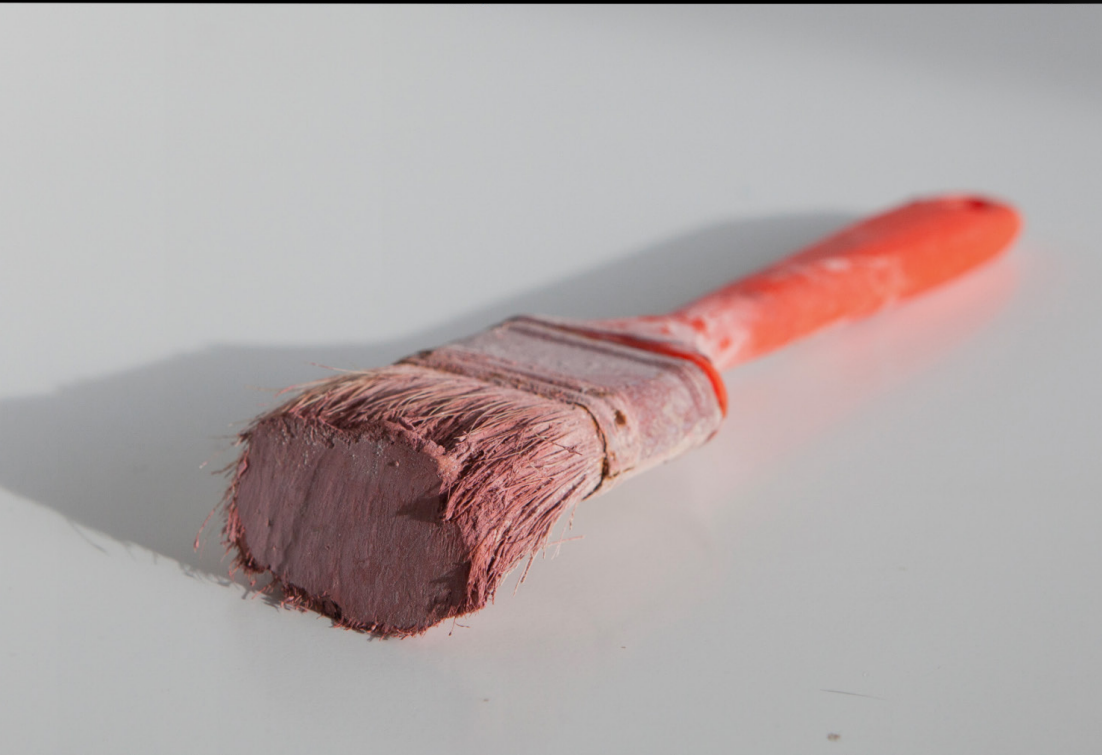
Look at this: this is what I got from Venice. It's nice isn't it?

Yes, but now, what to do with it? It is good the way it is. It was used for an exterior, a facade. Well, perhaps I've already projected onto it. I found it outside on the top of an electrical box attached to a house. So I like to think of it as the paintbrush that painted the plaster facade.

Yes, like a concealer brush – do you know this term? Or a corrector for makeup, a type of cosmetic that is used to mask dark circles, age spots, and small blemishes.

FIGURE 8

Hannah Parr, *The Makeup Brush of Venice*, 2019,
a dried paintbrush found on
Calle Ponte Sorto, Venice



(DECEMBER 9, 2019)

TOOLS

3

FIGURE 9

Tintoretto, *Miracle of the Slave* (detail), 1548 (Galleria dell' Accademia, Venice) The freed slave is shown lying atop the broken tools of slave labor.



3.1

In previous chapters I have spoken about acknowledging living machines, identifying magic in the mundane, overcoming a sense of impossibility, and the importance of empathy as a tool to create social awareness.

Turning now to the topic of transformation, I'd like to begin with this excerpt from Paul B. Preciado's *Feminism beyond humanism, ecology beyond the environment*:

“ Animalism is not a naturalism. It is a complete ritual system, a counter-technology for the production of consciousness. It is the conversion to a form of life without sovereignty, without any hierarchy. Animalism institutes its own law, its own economy. Animalism is not a contractual moralism. It refutes the aesthetics of capitalism and its capture of desire by consumption (of goods, ideas, information, bodies). It rests neither on exchange nor on individual interest. Animalism is not the revenge of one clan against another. Animalism is not a heterosexualism, nor a homosexualism, nor a transsexualism. Animalism is neither modern or postmodern. I can state, without joking, that animalism is not a hollandism. It is not a sarkoyzism or a bleumarinism. Animalism is not patriotism, nor a matriotism. Animalism is not a nationalism, nor a europeanism. Animalism is not a capitalism, nor a communism. The economy of animalism is a wholly non-agonistic sharing of benefits: a photosynthetic cooperation, a molecular pleasure. Animalism is the wind that blows. It is the way in which the spirit of the forest of atoms still has a hold on the thieves. Humans, the masked incarnations of the forest, should unmask themselves of the human and mask themselves again with the knowledge of the bees.

The change that is necessary is so profound that it will be said to be impossible. So profound that it will be said to be unimaginable. But the impossible is to come. And the imaginary is due. What was the most impossible and the most unimaginable, slavery or the end of slavery? The time of animalism is that of the impossible and the unimaginable. This is our time: the only one that remains.⁹ (page 50)

I find this passage compelling, as it affirms my experiences in the Chios hammam as indeed a form of “animalism” yet demonstrating a way to overcome the sense of impossibility.

3.2

Fairy tales often take place in forests, and transformation often takes place in fairy tales. The actions inside the hammam were to me transformative and led to the development of concepts I have since integrated into artworks (as in *Great Hair*, discussed in chapter 6.). In her book *The Cat, a Tale of Feminine Redemption*, Marie Louise Von Franz discusses how in history and fairy tales transformation is often associated with somersaults. I see what happened inside the hammam as a kind of somersault. People would enter one way and leave another: a brisk turnaround and split second of weightlessness. Although we make many “somersaults” in our daily lives, they can also be seen as decisive and symbolic points of change.

“ Often in fairy tales, a somersault is a way to transform. It is also a ritual of resurrection, for instance at Egyptian funerals. You find in the tombs paintings of dwarfs turning somersaults, doing all sorts of gymnastics but especially somersaults, and that was to help the resurrection of the king. The idea that resurrection is a kind of somersault. You go down and then you come up again in a new form. It might also have to do with the fact that, as you know the baby in a mother's womb, if it is born normally, often makes a somersault before birth and comes out head first. So the somersault can denote a birth process, and possibly the observation of this fact led the Egyptians to have clowns and clowning dwarfs – probably they were bushmen prisoners really – do somersaults along the route of the funeral procession of the king, which according to the texts was meant to support the king's resurrection process.¹⁰ (page 50)

RITUAL RENDERING

3.3

Transformation evolves from process.

Process depicts the rituals of my artistic life.

Focusing on these habits themselves activates the imagination and allows the viewer to create their own vision rather than seeing just mine. To me providing too many obvious “answers” that are inevitably interpreted can kill the spark of material language. This is my main practical interest: to propose the materials that I work with as

language themselves. To me this is most effectively achieved with as little manipulation as possible, when the art, so to speak, lies in its presentation: its display, framing, staging, or naming.

However, it is undeniably difficult for me to resist “making” art. In the end, which is more liberating? To create a body of work that you have thoroughly enjoyed crafting with your hands or to open up a discourse with a series of ideas or propositions that can be realised in the viewer’s eyes. Both are valid, although “made” or finished works are in some way a dead end, I still stand up for them and the satisfaction that finished works engender. Sometimes we have to play shallow or superficial in order to get deep: “cold things warm, warm things cool, wet things dry, and parched things get wet.”¹¹ (page 50)

This play with the shallow corresponds with my recurrent interest in formal qualities and the vernacular. I try to use this familiarity as a way through, after all. “The only way out is through.”¹² (page 50) (And by presenting everyday objects and imagery anew, an alternative normality is formed immediately. It’s an expansion that presses against our linear thinking. This straightness is brutal in our society and runs like a terrible ravine through our “forests of flourishing animalism.”

Ravines are lonely and violent places averse to settlement, as nothing can be built along their steep sides. The word “ravine” itself derives from the archaic “rapin,” which referred to a violent seizure of property. During times of heavy rains and snow melt, a ravine may be filled with violent, rushing water. This aggressive water has run through our institutions and museums to a point that all is being cleared away except for authoritarianism and propaganda. In this sense, we can say that the life force of society is rendered irrelevant and can actually hinder people from forming their own ideas. This is why it is so important for the artist not to work in an exclusionary manner, but to stay “local” and manipulate the mundane.

Last spring, I visited the Museo Nacional Centro De Arte Reina Sofia and saw *Hospice of Failed Utopias*, an exhibition of Luis Camnitzer’s

work. In Camnitzer’s long and versatile career as an artist, essayist, art critic, curator, and lecturer, he has continually proposed knowledge and the role of education within a broad and participative space. Seeing these works increased my hopes for creation and learning. In his words:

“ My Utopia is an egalitarian and just society, classless and creative, where power is equitably distributed. To engage in the process of this utopia, I need education to be creative and to help create, and I need what we call art to be educational and generate learning. So the accent in education is not on transferring information but on learning how to access it. And where art is concerned, it doesn’t lie on the object called an ‘artwork’ but on the processes that its presence generates in the viewer, and on how it transforms individuals, giving them independence in their own creativity without forcing them to continue consuming what I do as an artist. Art and education, then, are almost the same thing. ”

I was fortunate to grow up in an unconventional multiracial home that cultivated open-mindedness and made me aware of other alternatives. The house itself could be described as a work of art. To this day, my parents sleep in the workroom, even though all four children have grown up and moved out. The workroom is essentially my father’s studio, but we all had a desk of our own there at one point. The entire house and garden is essentially my mother’s studio, where the rituals of her artistic life are practised. My father draws in his sketchbook while my mother is in the garden ripping bark off logs from a fallen tree, wearing a pencil skirt and kitten heels. She is the artist behind a prolific avant-garde archive collected over almost fifty years. It is an eclectic collection characterized by an innate concern with sustainability: functional, artistic, and educational reuse. Arrangements of multiple saved plastic food containers juxtaposed with antique chinaware, French art deco wardrobes are filled with used wrapping paper from thirty-plus Christmasses, and

found mirrors come together stuck to the kitchen cupboards with Blu-tack to reflect more light into the kitchen. Was this symbolic? Was it tool making? Was it innovation? Was it art?

To me, it was a coherent polyvalent semantic system, and I am grateful for the many tongues it put inside my mouth.

SELECTA

4

FOOTNOTES:

9

Paul B. Preciado, 'Feminism beyond humanism, ecology beyond the environment', *Autonomies*, Posted by Julius Gavroche, <http://autonomies.org/2015/07/paul-beatriz-preciado-feminism-beyond-humanism-ecology-beyond-the-environment/>, (July 20, 2015)

10

Marie-Louise Von Franz, *The Cat, A Tale of Feminine Redemption* (Toronto, Inner City Books, 1999. Print.)

11

Samuel Béreau, 'Herakleitos of Ephesos discourse' Copyright ©. *Herakleitos of Ephesos*, <http://philoctetes.free.fr/heraclitefraneng.htm>

12

Leila Peacock, *Gebäck to the future*, quote from a randomly selected fortune cookie (Volumes Art Publishing days, Zurich, 2019.)

SELF-SERVICE IN PUBLIC SPACES

4.1

There is no real way to describe the process of finding one's materials and making your own selection. The appeal of each object varies. But what can be described is the sense of privacy:

the intimacy between the finder and the object. I never forget the circumstances in which I come across a found object. A bond is made that you don't forget.

It's similar to the process of making an observational drawing. You create a memorable moment and, unlike when taking a snapshot with your phone, a deeper connection is made.

The relationship I have with my materials relates to the relationships I have with people. In the way that we don't forget the features of a person or place close to us. We forever recognise the smells, textures, and stories attached.

Although my work often takes shape in urban and domestic landscapes, I want to draw a comparison to the aboriginal art of Australia, which has a deep-seated relationship to the land. Aboriginal art is about the land and made of materials gathered from the land. The works literally carry the landscape on its body. The continental landmass, or Mother Earth, is the aboriginal artist's canvas, a fertile, spiritual, and natural resource. For me working with found materials is about roaming and connecting with my surrounding environment.

Nonetheless, one of the comments I loathe the most is, "You would love it there – there are plenty of things you can collect." As if all artists that work with found materials are just keen to get their hands on a lot of old trash. It's not about mass or the need to make, it's about roaming to learn and pursuing diverse impulses and curiosity that naturally change shape according to their surroundings. But the territory of working with found materials is indeed a confusing one. How to define what is artifact and what is art? This question is known all too well by women with regard to the genealogy of the female in museums and art galleries: are we artefacts or artists?

UNDER THE TABLE

4.2

FIGURE 10

Hannah Parr, *Under the Table* (detail), 2019, 76cm × 85cm × 61cm, birch wood, lochplatte, salvaged wood offcuts and cable ties.



During the first semester of my MFA at the ZHdK, I salvaged fragments of scraped wood that had been flung into in-house woodshop bins. To my eye, these fragments resembled weaponry and ammunition. In my studio, I arranged the broken pieces on my desk, which converted them into a kind of army – an alliance of defunct scrap. Collectively, they were transformed into instruments of power. I attached everything to the underside of a school table and called the work *Under the Table*.

FIGURE 11

Hannah Parr, *Under the Table* (detail), 2019, 76cm x 85cm x 61cm, birch wood, lochplatte, salvaged wood offcuts and cable ties..



FIGURE 12

Hannah Parr, *Under the Table* (detail), 2019, 76cm x 85cm x 61cm, birch wood, lochplatte, salvaged wood offcuts and cable ties.



ALL KINDS OF TRIPPY

5

Matter Knows Matter:

As previously described, my artistic practice is centred around gathered materials that become vectors for speculation once inside the studio. They are a means to draw lines and determine territories of commonality. Why I choose certain objects and bring them back to the studio is often a mystery. As mentioned before, the appeal of an object or scrap varies, but there is an internal knowing, an instinct that pushes me to pick it up.

This daily search and practice relates well to a passage from Marie-Louise Von Franz's *Alchemy: An Introduction to the Symbolism and the Psychology* on Carl Jung's hypothesis concerning the connection between material matter and the unconscious. He proposes that the unconscious has a material aspect: it knows about matter because it is matter. It is matter that knows itself. This hints at a possible reason behind the mysterious process that I and other artists engage with in and outside their studios. I need to roam and dig around in the mud daily, but not all of us do. Perhaps it's a question of natural tendencies. If someone is drawn to working with materials, then it's usually because it comes naturally to them. It's not as if you make a decision and say, "Well, I am going to work with materials because I've never tried that before." Artistic practise is not a hobby.

" As you know, there was a famous quarrel between Max Planck and Einstein, in which Einstein claimed that, on paper, the human mind was capable of inventing mathematical models of reality. In this, he generalized his own experience because that is what he did. Einstein conceived his theories more or less completely on paper, and experimental developments in physics proved that his models explained phenomena very well. So Einstein says that the fact that a model constructed by the human mind in an introverted situation fits with outer facts is just a miracle and must be taken as such. Plank does not agree but thinks that we conceive a model which we check by experiment, after which we revise our model so that there is a kind of dialectic friction between experiment and model by which we slowly arrive at an explanatory fact compounded of the two. Plato-Aristotle in a new form! But both have forgotten something, the unconscious. We know something more than those two men, namely that when Einstein makes a new model of reality he is helped by his unconscious, without which he would not have arrived at his theories.

But what role does the unconscious play? The unconscious seems to deliver models which can be arrived at directly from within without looking at outer facts, and which afterwards seem to fit outer reality. Is that a miracle or not? There are two possible explanations: either the unconscious knows about other realities, or what we call the unconscious is a part of the same thing as outer reality, for we do not know how the unconscious is linked with matter. If a wonderful idea as how to explain gravitation comes up from within me, can I say that it is the nonmaterial unconscious giving me a wonderful idea about material reality, or should I say that the unconscious gives me such a marvellous idea of outer reality because it is itself linked with matter, it is a phenomenon of matter and matter knows matter?

There we are at our wit's end as to how to proceed and have to leave the question open and say that the great X is that we do not know how to proceed. We can make two hypotheses. Dr. Jung is inclined to think though he has never formulated the thought, or only hypothetically, because we cannot do more, we can only speculate or make a hypothesis that probably the unconscious has a material aspect, which would be why it knows about matter, because it is matter, it is matter which knows itself, as it were.¹³ (page 60)

In regards to my own work processes, I put a good deal of trust in my unconscious activity. I find it to be a faithful companion, as faithful as our own breath. Our breath is there to support us and keep us calm, but only if we let it do what it naturally wants to. Likewise, our unconscious is there to support us and is much smarter than our dominant conscious mind. As Leila Peacock puts it, "We know more than we can tell."¹⁴ (page 60)

Accordingly, I give time to observe and transcribe my dreams and trust in my belly navigation. To transcribe my dreams is simply a way of exercising the unconscious muscle, as it were. I don't investigate the interpretation of dreams as a field of study; rather, I just watch and over time start to understand my own set of symbols and begin to learn from them. I've also found other ways to exercise the unconscious inside the studio. For instance, sanding or cutting wood can be a meditative and therapeutic process of just looking and listening, undoing and stripping, dissecting, organising, and arranging. With this type of woodwork, it is the material that possesses the unconscious quality. It expresses its material language, then later I make my conscious decisions about how to proceed. Whereas with painting, the paint is plastic and unborn. Until it has reached the mixing pallet, it hasn't done anything and has nothing attached to it until I interact with it. Only after entering a kind of hypnotic state spurred through the physical motion of painting is a connection with my unconscious established.

BASIC BITCH

6

AFFIRMATIVE HAIR FLICKING

6.1

Females, bitches, whores, and witches are flexible. Like cats, they are able to wag their tails; therefore, by nature they are able to see more and maintain more inclusive perspectives. Just as our feline friends wag their tails, I invite us to flick our hair in a similar fashion.

FOOTNOTES:

13

Marie-Louise Von Franz, *Alchemy An Introduction to the Symbolism and the Psychology* (Toronto, Inner City Books, 1980. Print.)

14

Leila Peacock, a visual essay, *On Metaphor: An Essay In Fragments* on the walls of Gesnerallee (Zurich 2015.)

FIGURE 13

Hannah Parr, *Great Hair*, 2019,
size variable, paint brush,
synthetic blond wig



RECLAIMING MATERIALS AND THE HIDDEN POWER OF GENDER STEREOTYPES

6.2

I am currently working on a series of works that consider the process of reclaiming materials as a means to reclaim power from certain gender stereotypes. *Great Hair*, the first of this series, looks at transforming power tools closely associated with “manliness” into perverse symbols that explore female sexuality and identity. I replaced the bristles of a used paintbrush with an entire blond synthetic wig. Evaluating this synthetic material, I found a truth that parallels those of everyday life. Synthetic chemistry, a product of synthesis: a reaction of multiple elements and compounds to form more complex compounds. Life is complex, as are we. There are basic aspects of life that unify us, but this doesn’t legitimize stereotypical classifications.

Throughout this thesis, I have saluted a synthetic thread throughout my reflections: our No.1 sex symbol, Marilyn Monroe, whose aura is present in each of the experiences I have related, from Paramount Pictures, to America’s imports to the DR, to the women on stage at St. Paul’s church in Hackney, to the hammam, and to my own mother, glamorously dressed at work in the garden. What does this say about the pervasive power of an icon, a fictitious reality yet a very real influence? How do sex symbols, who if read correctly can be strong and significant figures, become relentlessly belittled. It’s a great line of absurdity in our society,

how something of real significance can be manipulated into insignificance, how society can turn our best bitches into basic bitches.

“ A sex symbol is usually defined in terms of their excessive sexuality, which is seen as a manifestaion of and commentary on, shifting scoial relations of class gender and sexuality. They are a transgressive figure who is driven by sexual desire and materialism to challenge traditional social boundaries and is often demonised and criminalised as an instrument of consumerism, even if they are celebrated for their independence. Rather like the femme fatal of the 1940s, the post second world war sex symbol represented an ambivilant cultural response to the increasing sexual and economic emancipation of women and its perceived threat to the family.¹⁵ (page 64) ”

In this power tool series, I would like to contest these historical misinterpretations by reclaiming the *basic bitch* and applauding new forms of Contra Sex Symbols. In the same way that chemists synthesize chemical compounds that occur in nature to gain a better understanding of their structures, we too need to flick our hair (synthetic or not) in order to gain a better understanding of social structures.

FOOTNOTES:

15

Pam Cook, *The trouble with sex: Diana Dors and the Blonde bombshell phenomenon*, In: Bruce Babinigton, *British Stars and Stardom: From Alma Taylor to Sean Connery*, pp. 169–171. (Manchester University Press, 2001).

DIY

7

Bauhaus Renovation

My recent endeavors in the fields of Tools and Makeovers might be considered a renovation: a DIY project that crosses paths with and draws comparisons between the stereotyped territories of workshops, beauty salons, car body shops, and nail bars. The design of this renovation is inspired by the Bauhaus concepts of functionality, simplicity, and innovation.

FIGURE 14

Hannah Parr, *Bauhaus Vagina*, 2019, 55cm x 56cm x 80cm, an augmented Marcel Breuer black leather cantilever tubular arm-chair.



Bauhaus Vagina is an example of these works. Using the Bauhaus philosophy against itself to recharge and generate new messages, I made four cuts into the seat of the chair using an angle grinder. On the one hand, I am expressing my own practice as a female artist who uses power tools and often works in workshop environments with strongly gendered relations. On the other, I attempt to reclaim the force of unjustly belittled sex symbols. The beauty salon, for example, is commonly considered a frivolous place for both men and women, yet it remains a socially essential space. We visit places of “repair” not just to fix things, but to connect with each other and build communities. Unfortunately, what these symbols can really stand for gets hidden behind falsifying makeup, thus suffocating the natural curves of our societies. By analyzing the tools and architecture of heavily stereotyped spaces, I am investigating how to fundamentally rethink their underlying concepts. Inspired by the Bauhaus movement to fundamentally rethink *the home*, we must

strip off masks and wallpapers to unveil core messages that stand for restorative exchange, the potential for growth, and the renewal or discovery of sources of empowerment in unexpectedly familiar places.

MUNDANE

8

If we view the world as a sentient system, it reveals itself not as a thing but as a process that is always coming into being through interactions and contingencies.

Menot

Rafael is an old man that hangs around all day and all night sitting in his wheelchair outside of the Colmado on the corner of my street

in La Zona. He lives next door in a seafoam green house that is teeming with cats. One day I went to the Colmado to buy water. One of the young guys that works there, who usually dressed in a T-shirt and shorts, stood behind the counter wearing a round straw hat and a floral dress. Rafael was outside singing opera.

Appreciating this display, I decided to stop and talk to Rafael, seeing as he had tried to speak with me the day before but I didn't have time to stop. He was curious to know what I did and what type of painter I was. I told him I paint with colour and build sculptures. He said, "I like that because colour is something that can describe everything." Rafael speaks continuously, with everyone and no one, drifting in and out of his monologue. Our conversation continues and in-between talking about Monet, which he pronounces as "Menot," he mentions how some artists piss and shit on their paintings and it's okay because after it dries it doesn't smell. Like a dead person, the canvas can be approached after three days if you cover your nose and breathe through your mouth.

He went on to talk about his life and that he had lived in NYC in the '60s. He didn't study but worked in a factory and went on to work for a silkscreen printer. I mentioned it was time for me to leave he said 'I don't know anything about you, whether you are married or if you're in a relationship or if you're someone's daughter – but I know you're a VIP.' When I challenge his assessment, he counters, "No, you are a VIP because you have your own style. I can see you're very busy, but most importantly you listen and that's what makes you a VIP."

A man that talks continually day and night must be used to people not listening, so of course he appreciates it once in a while when someone stops to listen. In the DR, people are the street. They even metamorphose into the street. Types like Rafael don't die. The monotony, the heat, the stench of bad plumbing, and the salty polluted ocean air petrify them. For sure Rafael is at the Colmado right now.

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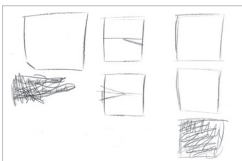
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